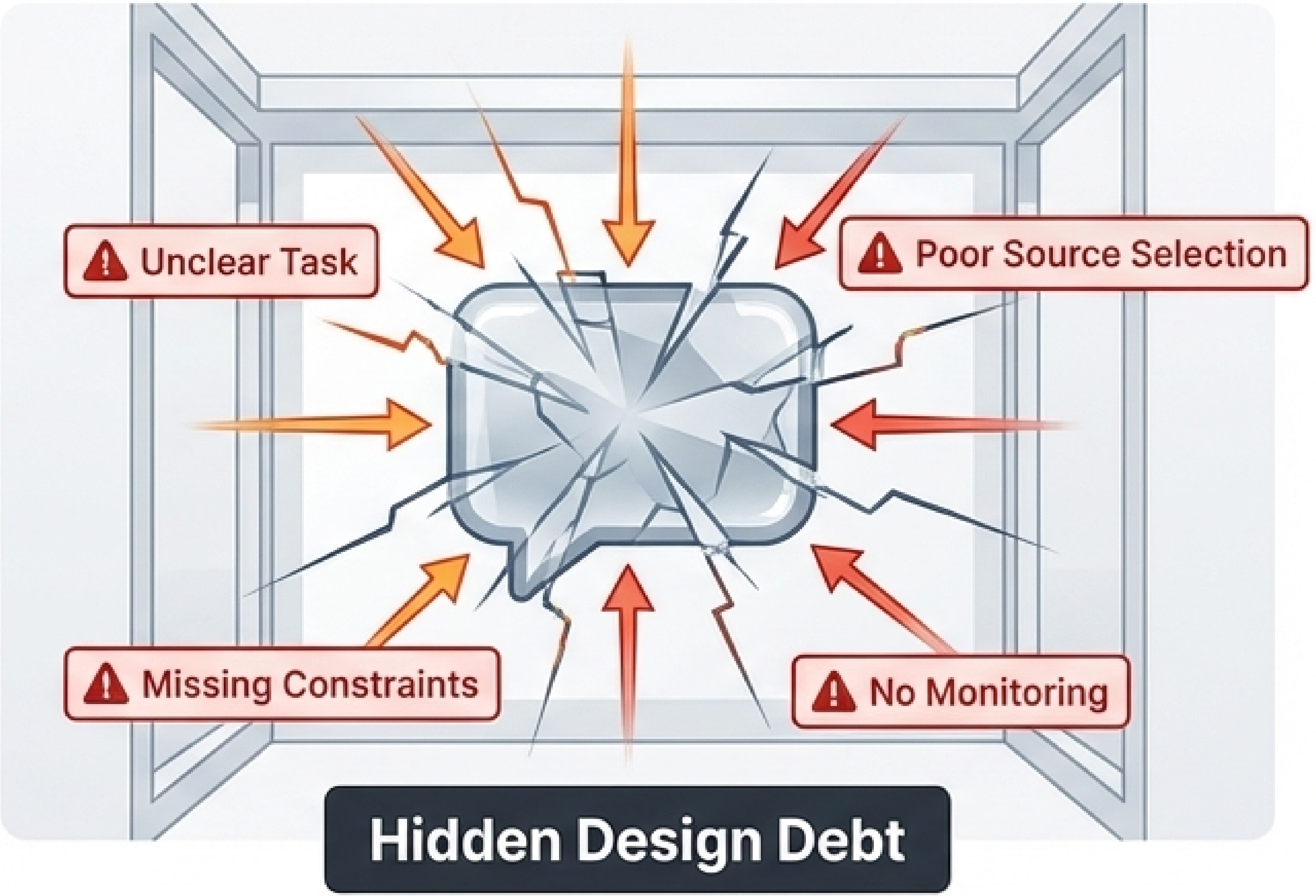
The Context Engineering Lifecycle

A 7-Phase Blueprint for Reliable AI

Instead of treating context engineering as a single act of prompt writing, this framework treats it as an operational lifecycle. Move from intuitive guessing to durable, artifact-driven problem solving.

A reliable demo is not a reliable design.



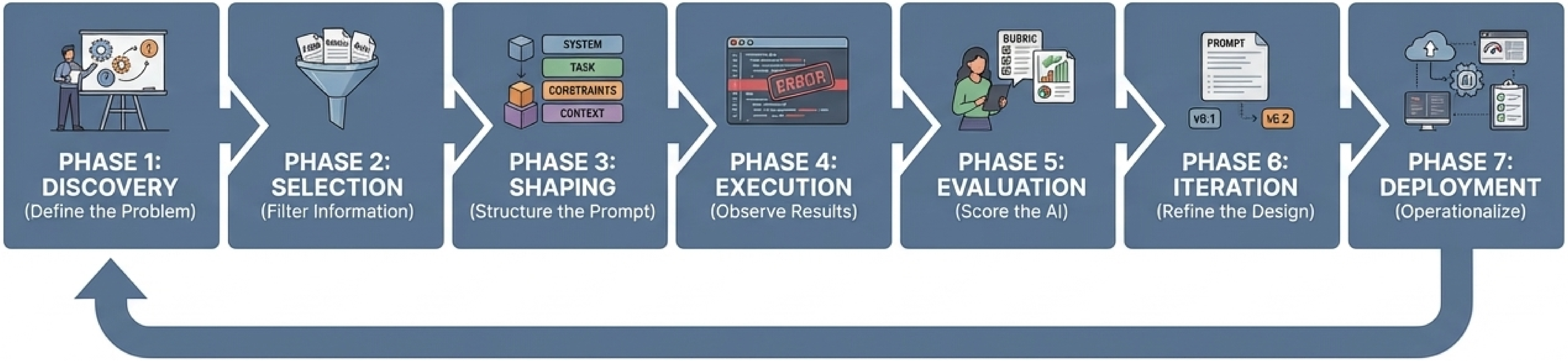
Generative AI work is vulnerable to hidden design debt. When teams focus only on wording the prompt, they fix symptoms while leaving the real design problem untouched.

Moving from intuition to engineering.

Intuitive Prompting	Context Engineering
One-shot creative exercise	Disciplined operational lifecycle
Subjective gut-feel evaluation	Evidence-based rubric scoring
Start by writing instructions	Define success before writing
Lives in chat history	Produces durable artifacts

Visible artifacts turn subjective debate into reviewable evidence.

The 7-Phase Context Engineering Lifecycle



In practice, this is not a one-time march from left to right. It is a controlled loop. Evolving expectations and new policies mean deployment feeds right back into discovery.

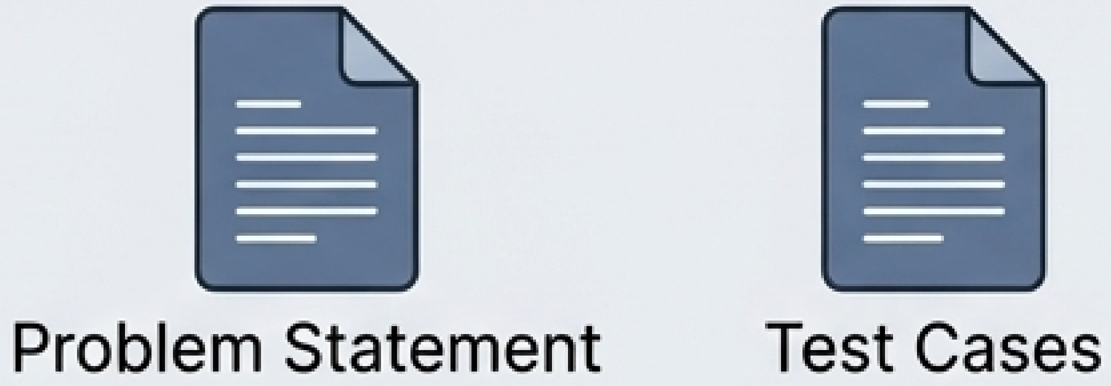
Phase 1: Define success before writing prompts.

Translate broad ambitions into a bounded job-to-be-done with explicit success criteria and representative test queries.

Bounded Constraints

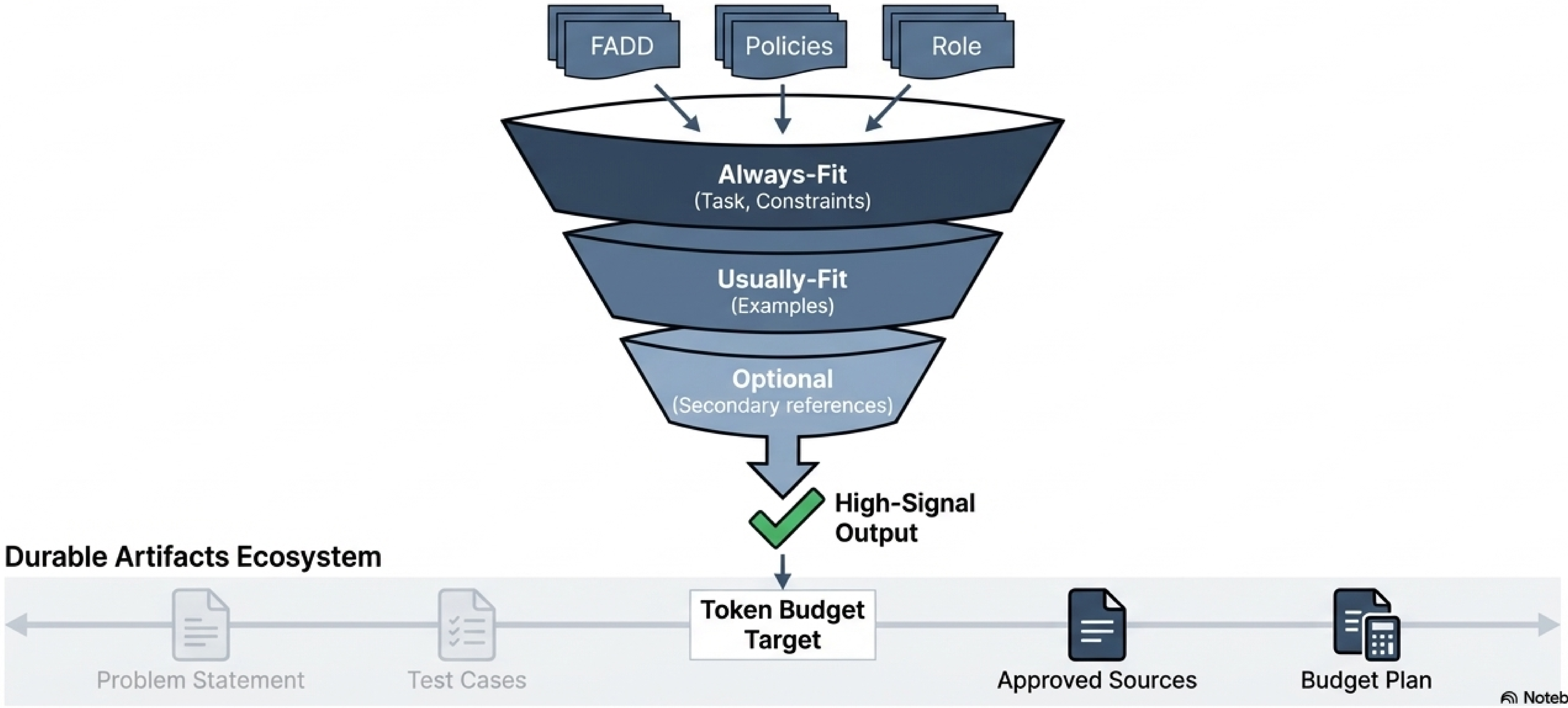
- Target Task
- Intended Users
- Success Criteria
- Edge Cases

Durable Artifacts Ecosystem



Phase 2: Filter for high-signal context

The context window is finite. Over-selection competes for the model's attention and dilutes critical instructions.



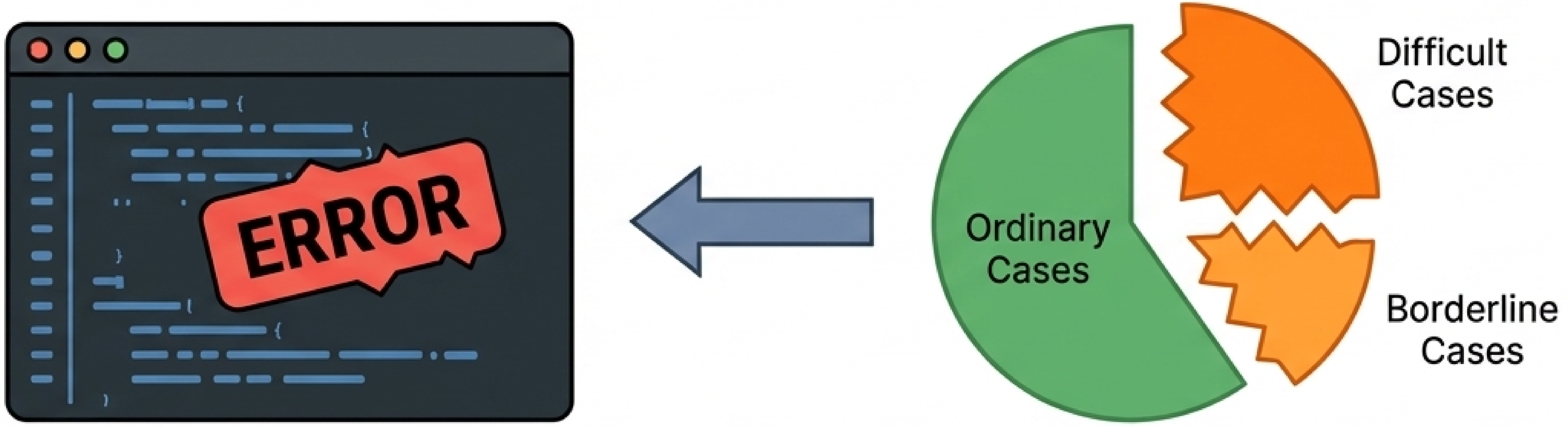
Phase 3: Build a reviewable context skeleton

Separate instructions, evidence, dynamic facts, and user requests so the model can distinguish rules from data.

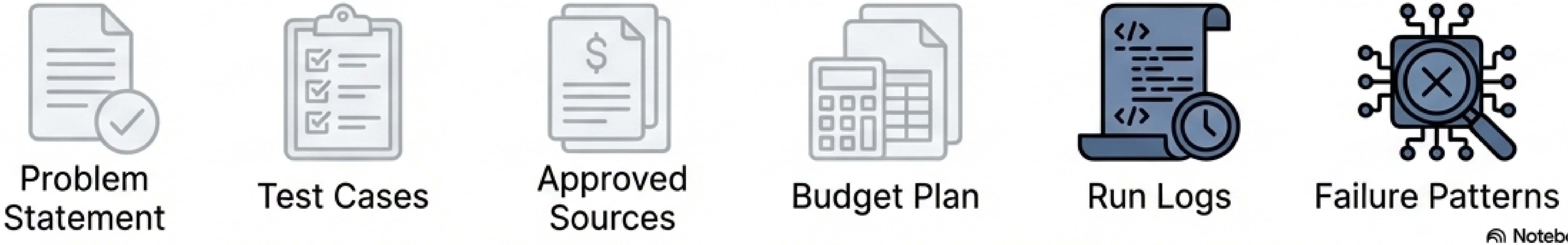
Durable Artifacts Ecosystem

Phase 4: Execute on representative reality.

Run the design on ordinary, difficult, and borderline cases. Capture outputs systematically to serve as an evidence baseline.



Durable Artifacts Ecosystem



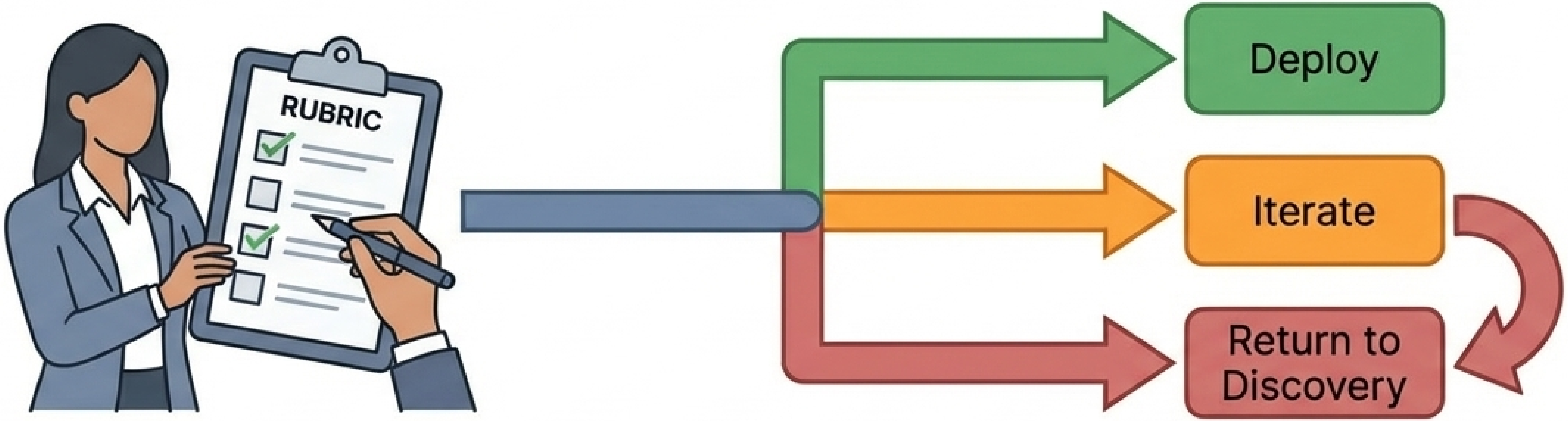
The 0-1-2 Evaluation Scorecard

A repeatable framework to replace subjective gut feel

Criteria	0 (Missed / Violated)	1 (Partial / Inconsistent)	2 (Met Clearly / Reliably)
Accuracy	❌ Materially wrong or unsupported	➖ Partly right but incomplete or uncertain	✅ Correct and appropriately grounded
Completeness	❌ Misses major needed content	➖ Addresses part of the task	✅ Covers the task to the needed depth
Constraint Adherence	❌ Violates key rule or boundary	➖ Mostly compliant but inconsistent	✅ Consistently follows stated rules
Usability	❌ Hard to act on	➖ Partly usable	✅ Clear, structured, ready to use

Phase 5: Score evidence, not impressions.

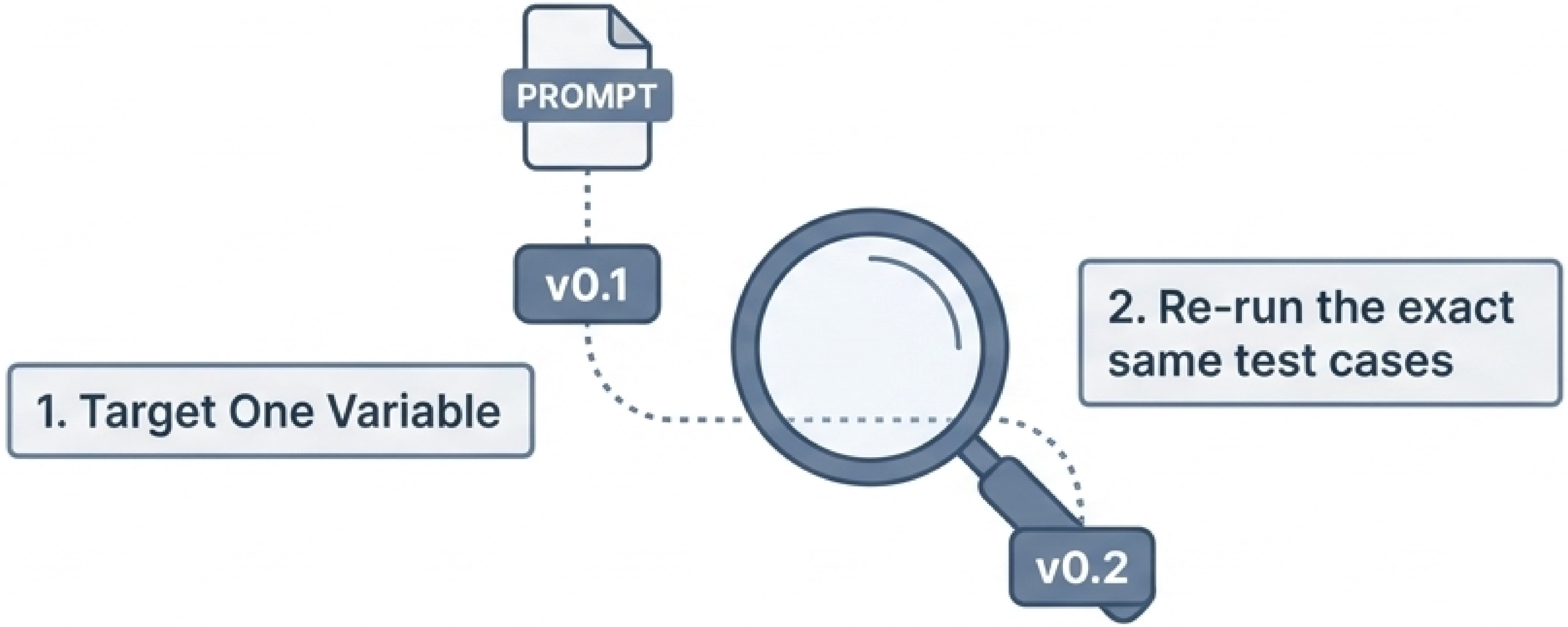
Compare captured outputs against explicit success criteria to identify recurring failure modes.

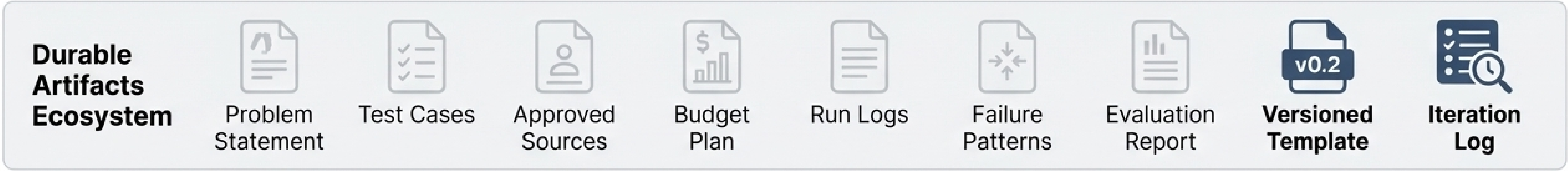


Durable Artifacts Ecosystem

Phase 6: Refine through controlled regression

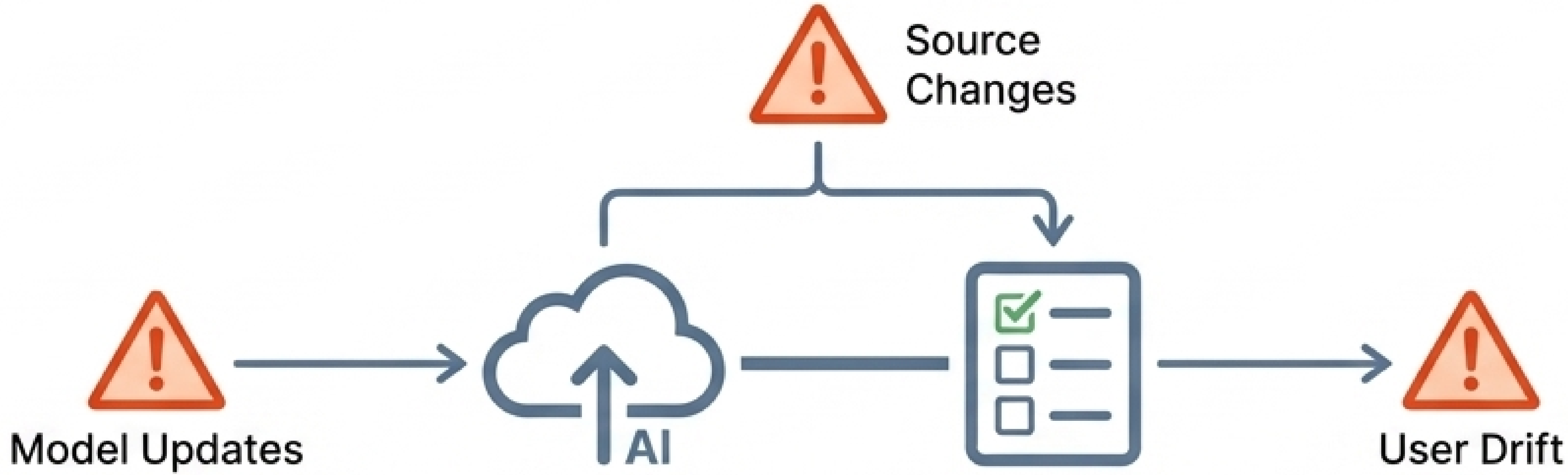
Adjust one meaningful variable at a time to fix specific failures without breaking previously successful outputs.





Phase 7: Operationalize and monitor for drift.

Deployment is not the end. Define ownership, monitor logging, and establish an update policy as software or user queries change.



Durable Artifacts Ecosystem

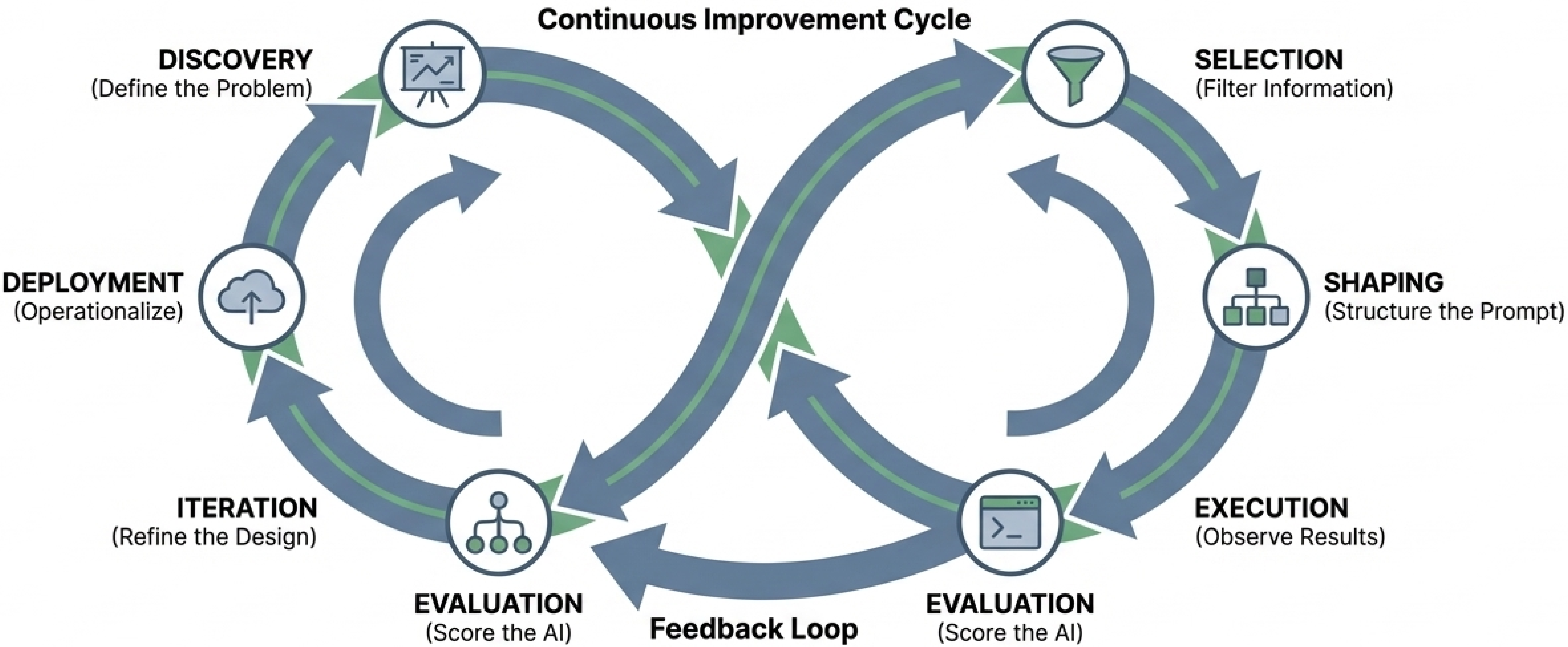
The cost of skipping discipline.

Each skipped phase removes a type of discipline that later phases depend on.

The Skipped Phase	Predictable Failure Pattern
Skipped Discovery	Optimizing the wrong task because success was never defined precisely.
Skipped Selection	Context overload, causing the model to become verbose and distracted.
Skipped Shaping	Mixed prompts where rules and facts blur, making failures hard to diagnose.
Skipped Evaluation	Random rewrites and guesswork replacing targeted iteration.

Linear is an illusion: The Controlled Loop.

The true output of this lifecycle isn't just a deployed AI model; it's an adaptable, self-correcting business system.



The Knowledge Worker's Advantage.

You own the business problem. **Context** engineering proides, provides the **operational discipline** to ensure generative AI **solves it reliably**.